could be told to future generations. The story of its rebirth is a story that every Indian should be proud of.

STORIES AROUND INDIA'S FIRST BULLET TRAIN

As India is now gearing up for the next generation of trains in the form of the bullet train, things are coming full circle. Originally proposed by Prime Minister Manmohan Singh hoping to develop world class passenger systems, high speed passenger trains running at 350 kmph were first mentioned in the Parliament by Railway Minister Lalu Prasad Yadav in February 2007.

He said, 'India is today seen as a growing power in the world. The rapid growth of the economy, rising industrialization and urbanization, and unprecedented growth in intercity travel have opened up infinite possibilities for developing high speed passenger corridors. Therefore, we have decided to conduct pre-feasibility studies for construction of high speed passenger corridors, equipped with state-of-the-art signalling and train control systems, for running high speed trains at 300–350 kmph; one each in the northern, western, southern and eastern regions of the country.' [153]

The idea moved ahead in his February 2009 Interim Budget speech, where he announced among five different corridors, the Ahmedabad-Mumbai-Pune route with work 'soon to begin for a pre-feasibility study'. The proposed stations, including Lonavala in the Mumbai–Pune section and Surat, Bharuch and Vadodara in the Mumbai-Ahmedabad section, would have an eventual extension to Bengaluru.

Agreements followed in 2013 with the French National Railways, Société Nationale des Chemins de Fer Français (SNCF), for technical cooperation and feasibility report for 'operations and development'. The Pune section was dropped due to the mountainous ghat terrain that could lead to cost escalation, leaving just the Mumbai-Ahmedabad corridor as feasible.

The Japanese Come In

In September the same year, India signed a deal for a joint feasibility study [154] with Japanese Prime Minister Shinzo Abe during his India visit in